Sanaul Haque

Hurayin_Fairuze_Suha_Proposal

Assignment 1066

Document Details

Submission ID
trn:oid:::3117:636194850

Submission Date
Oct 8, 2026, 11:42 PM GMT+6

Download Date
Oct 8, 2026, 11:46 PM GMT+6

File Name
Hurayin_Fairuze_Suha_Proposal.pdf

File Size
540.7 KB

10 Pages

2,886 Words

17,705 Characters

12% Overall Similarity

The combined total of all matches, including overlapping sources, for each database.

Match Groups

- **12** Not Cited or Quoted 8%
  Matches with neither in-text citation nor quotation marks
- **3** Missing Quotations 1%
  Matches that are still very similar to source material
- **4** Missing Citation 3%
  Matches that have quotation marks, but no in-text citation
- **0** Cited and Quoted 0%
  Matches with in-text citation present, but no quotation marks

Top Sources

10% Internet sources
5% Publications
10% Submitted works (Student Papers)

Match Groups

- **12** Not Cited or Quoted 8%
  Matches with neither in-text citation nor quotation marks
- **3** Missing Quotations 1%
  Matches that are still very similar to source material
- **4** Missing Citation 3%
  Matches that have quotation marks, but no in-text citation
- **0** Cited and Quoted 0%
  Matches with in-text citation present, but no quotation marks

Top Sources

10% Internet sources
5% Publications
10% Submitted works (Student Papers)

Top Sources

The sources with the highest number of matches within the submission. Overlapping sources will not be displayed.

1	Internet	
www.mdpi.com		1%
2	Student papers	
Cardiff University on 2019-05-03		1%
3	Internet	
in-mind.org		1%
4	Internet	
www.grafiati.com		<1%
5	Internet	
ijesc.org		<1%
6	Internet	
journal.frontiersin.org		<1%
7	Publication	
Lucy R. Betts, Sarah L. Buglass, Loren Abell, Oonagh L. Steer, Angelica Balaos. "Un...		<1%
8	Internet	
www.citeulike.org		<1%
9	Internet	
www.scilit.net		<1%
10	Student papers	
University College London on 2013-09-02		<1%

11 Internet

assets-eu.researchsquare.com <1%

12 Internet

essay365.x10.mx <1%

13 Student papers

Goldsmiths' College on 2015-03-25 <1%

14 Internet

www.jait.us <1%

15 Student papers

UCL on 2025-05-06 <1%

16 Internet

www.classace.io <1%

17 Student papers

City University of Hong Kong on 2017-02-27 <1%

18 Student papers

University of Birmingham on 2020-01-19 <1%

RESEARCH PROPOSAL

From Humor to Harassment: Exploring the Normalization of Misogynistic Language Among Friends

A Proposal for a Mixed-Methods Study on Peer-Group Talk, Gender and the Escalation of Sexist Speech

Submitted by: Hurayin Fairuze Suha

Submitted to: IARCO

Institution: Cantonment English School and College

Class: XII

Country: Bangladesh

Date: 20th September 2026

Abstract

Misogynistic language is frequently dismissed within friendship groups as “just a joke” or “banter,” yet a growing body of research suggests that such talk plays an active role in normalizing hostility toward women and in creating social conditions that tolerate and sometimes escalate into, harassment. This proposal outlines a mixed-methods study examining how misogynistic language circulates, is negotiated and is normalized within same-sex and mixed-sex friendship groups of young adults aged 18–25. Drawing on prejudiced norm theory [1], ambivalent sexism theory [2] and feminist theorizing on the continuum of sexual violence [3], the study combines a survey (N ≈ 250) with semi-structured interviews and friendship-group focus discussions (N ≈ 24–30) to examine the frequency, forms and perceived acceptability of misogynistic language, the social functions it serves within peer bonding and the conditions under which “joking” talk shifts toward harassment or is challenged by group members. The study is expected to contribute empirically grounded insight into an under-examined social mechanism of gender-based harm and to inform byst ander-intervention and campus/community prevention programming.

1. Introduction

Jokes, nicknames, insults and offh and remarks that demean women are a routine feature of many friendship groups and they are typically framed by participants as harmless fun rather than as a form of prejudice [4]. This framing matters: research on disparagement humor shows that when discriminatory content is delivered as a joke, listeners are encouraged to adopt a “non-serious” frame of mind that suspends their usual critical judgment, effectively licensing the expression of prejudice without fear of social sanction [1]. Because friendship groups are one of the primary contexts in which young people rehearse social norms, they are also a primary site where the boundaries of acceptable speech about women are set, tested and reinforced.

At the same time, feminist scholarship has long argued that everyday, low-level forms of sexist speech and conduct are not separate from more serious forms of gender-based harm but exist on a single continuum, such that the normalization of “minor” verbal disrespect helps sustain a broader climate in which harassment and abuse are tolerated [3]. Sociolinguistic and masculinity studies research on “banter” similarly shows that humor within male peer groups functions less as a neutral expression of individual attitudes and more as a ritualized social practice that builds male bonds partly at women’s expense [5], [6]. Despite this, most existing research has examined disparagement humor in controlled

laboratory settings or in mediated contexts such as magazines and social media, leaving the everyday, face-to-face talk of friendship groups comparatively under-studied. This proposal addresses that gap.

2. Statement of the Problem

Misogynistic language among friends is often treated, by both participants and researchers, as trivial precisely because it occurs in informal, affectionate and ostensibly consensual settings. Yet this triviality is itself part of the mechanism by which sexist attitudes are reproduced and defended: humor provides plausible deniability ("it's just a joke"), diffuses individual responsibility across the group and creates local norms of tolerance that can extend beyond the joke itself [7], [8]. What remains poorly understood is how this normalization process unfolds in practice within real friendship groups over time: how misogynistic language is introduced and repeated, how it is policed or left unchallenged, how its meaning shifts across contexts and audiences and under what conditions it moves from what participants regard as playful teasing toward language and conduct that targets, humiliates, or harasses specific women. Without this underst anding, interventions aimed at reducing gender-based harassment risk overlooking one of its most common precursors: the everyday talk of friends.

3. Literature Review

3.1 Disparagement Humor and Prejudiced Norm Theory

Ford and Ferguson's prejudiced norm theory [1] provides the most influential account of how disparagement humor functions socially. The theory holds that a joke and its reception form an implicit "contract" to interpret potentially offensive material non-seriously; by laughing along, the recipient tacitly signals acceptance of a local norm that it is acceptable, in this context, to make light of discrimination. Experimental work in this tradition has repeatedly found that exposure to sexist jokes, relative to neutral jokes or non-humorous sexist statements, increases tolerance of subsequent discriminatory behavior toward women, particularly among individuals who already score highly on measures of hostile sexism [7], [8]. This body of research establishes a plausible causal mechanism — humor as a "prejudice releaser" — but has been conducted almost entirely through laboratory exposure to pre-written jokes rather than through the organic, evolving talk of real social groups.

3.2 Ambivalent Sexism and Media Normalization

Glick and Fiske's ambivalent sexism framework [2] distinguishes hostile sexism (overt antagonism toward women) from benevolent sexism (paternalistic attitudes that appear positive but reinforce traditional

gender roles) and shows that both forms coexist and reinforce one another. This distinction is useful for the proposed study because misogynistic language among friends rarely presents as uniformly hostile; it frequently blends affectionate teasing, protective paternalism and derogatory remarks in the same conversation. Related research on “lads’ mags” found that ambivalent sexism predicted young men’s consumption of hyper-masculine media and that presenting sexist jokes within such a context made them appear less overtly hostile even though their content mirrored language used by convicted rapists to justify sexual violence [9]. This suggests that the framing and setting in which misogynistic language occurs — including friendship contexts — shapes how harmful it is perceived to be, independent of its actual content.

3.3 Banter, Masculinity and Peer-Group Bonding

Sociological and sociolinguistic research on “banter” offers the closest existing analogue to the present study’s focus on friendship groups. Nichols [6] found that men in a rugby club used “mischievous masculinities” — banter that simultaneously constructed and appeared to deconstruct sexist ideas — to frame everyday sexism as innocent, even as participants privately acknowledged its problematic character. Whittle, Elder-Vass and Lumsden [5] similarly found that banter among male teenagers on social media served as a means of performing hegemonic masculinity, negotiating in-group status and policing peer boundaries and that it could shade into bullying and “overflow” into other harmful practices. Related work on racial joking among college students found that participants routinely reframed prejudiced humor as harmless while relying on group membership and shared identity to neutralize its perceived harm, a pattern the authors term “neutralized hegemonic banter” [10]. Taken together, this literature indicates that peer-group humor is not incidental to gendered harm but is one of the social mechanisms through which such harm is rehearsed, normalized and occasionally resisted.

3.4 From Everyday Talk to Harassment: The Continuum of Violence

Kelly's concept of the continuum of sexual violence [3] argues that behaviors ranging from verbal harassment and objectifying comments to assault and rape are not discrete categories but interconnected expressions of the same underlying structure of gendered power, such that ordinary, frequently occurring behaviors normalize the conditions for more extreme forms of violence. Applied to friendship-group talk, this framework suggests that misogynistic jokes and insults should not be studied purely as isolated speech acts but as part of a graduated social practice that can, under certain conditions, extend into targeted harassment of specific women — whether within the friend group, in romantic or ex-romantic contexts, or online. Qualitative research with women who have experienced sexist humor in academic

and social settings similarly documents a range of responses — confrontation, silent withdrawal and reluctant participation — that reveal the coercive pressure such humor exerts even on those who are its target [4].

3.5 Gaps in the Literature

Three gaps justify the proposed study. First, most experimental research on disparagement humor relies on researcher-supplied jokes rather than naturally occurring talk, limiting ecological validity. Second, existing qualitative work on banter and masculinity has focused primarily on all-male or predominantly male settings (e.g., sports clubs, online forums), leaving mixed-sex and female friendship groups comparatively unexamined. Third, few studies trace the trajectory from "joking" language to conduct that participants themselves would classify as harassment, meaning the tipping point between normalized banter and recognized harm remains poorly specified. The proposed study addresses each of these gaps.

4. Theoretical Framework

The study integrates three complementary frameworks. Prejudiced norm theory [1] explains the micro-level social mechanism by which humor licenses the expression of prejudice within a given interaction. Ambivalent sexism theory [2] provides a lens for classifying the hostile and benevolent forms that misogynistic language takes, since friendship talk often blends both. Kelly's continuum of sexual violence [3] supplies the macro-level structural argument connecting everyday verbal normalization to the broader tolerance of gender-based harassment. Together, these frameworks position friendship-group talk as a socially situated practice that both reflects and actively produces the boundaries of acceptable conduct toward women.

1

5. Research Questions and Objectives

This study is guided by the following research questions:

- RQ1: How frequently and in what forms, does misogynistic language occur within friendship groups of young adults and how do group members characterize its intent and acceptability?
- RQ2: What social functions (e.g., bonding, status negotiation, boundary-testing) does misogynistic language serve within friendship groups?
- RQ3: Under what conditions is misogynistic language challenged, resisted, or left unchallenged by group members, including women present in the group?

- RQ4: What conditions or triggers are associated with a shift from language perceived as "joking" toward language or conduct that participants themselves identify as harassment?

Corresponding objectives are to: (1) quantify the prevalence and perceived acceptability of misogynistic language among a sample of young adults; (2) develop a qualitative account of how such language is introduced, sustained and normalized within friendship groups; (3) identify the interactional and structural conditions under which such language escalates or is successfully challenged and (4) generate evidence-based recommendations for byst ander-intervention and prevention programming.

6. Methodology

11

6.1 Research Design

The study adopts a sequential explanatory mixed-methods design. An initial quantitative survey will establish the prevalence, forms and perceived normativity of misogynistic language across a broad sample, while a subsequent qualitative phase — semi-structured individual interviews and friendship-group focus discussions — will explore the interactional dynamics, meanings and escalation patterns that a survey alone cannot capture. This design allows the qualitative phase to be purposively informed by patterns identified in the survey data (e.g., recruiting focus groups from friendship networks that reported high versus low tolerance of such language).

6.2 Participants and Sampling

Participants will be young adults aged 18–25, recruited from university and community settings via campus organizations, social media and snowball sampling through existing friendship networks. The survey phase will target approximately 250 participants (stratified where possible by gender identity) recruited as individuals. The qualitative phase will recruit approximately 6–8 intact friendship groups (24–30 participants total), including both predominantly male, predominantly female and mixed-sex groups, to allow comparison across group composition. Recruiting intact friendship groups, rather than unconnected individuals, is essential because the phenomenon under study is fundamentally relational and group-based.

6.3 Data Collection

The survey will include validated measures adapted from the Ambivalent Sexism Inventory [2], items assessing exposure to and participation in misogynistic joking (adapted from disparagement-humor research [7], [8]) and original items assessing perceived group norms and instances of escalation to

15 harassment. Semi-structured interviews (45–60 minutes) will explore individual participants' experiences, perceptions and reflections on group norms, including moments where they felt discomfort, complicity, or a desire to intervene. Friendship-group focus discussions (60–90 minutes) will use vignette-based prompts drawn from anonymized, researcher-constructed scenarios (rather than requesting participants reproduce specific real remarks about identifiable people) to elicit group negotiation of what counts as acceptable joking versus harassment, allowing the research team to observe — within the safety of a facilitated discussion — how such judgments are actually contested among peers.

12 ### 6.4 Data Analysis

Survey data will be analyzed using descriptive statistics and regression models examining associations between ambivalent sexism scores, group gender composition and reported tolerance/escalation of misogynistic language. Interview and focus-group transcripts will be analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis, with coding informed by, but not limited to, the constructs of prejudiced norm theory and the continuum of violence, allowing inductive themes to emerge alongside theoretically anticipated ones.

16

6.5 Rigor and Trustworthiness

Quantitative rigor will be supported through pilot testing of survey items, reliability analysis of adapted scales and appropriate sampling weights. Qualitative trustworthiness will be supported through investigator triangulation (independent coding by at least two researchers with reconciliation of discrepancies), maintenance of an audit trail and member-checking of preliminary themes with a subset of participants.

7. Ethical Considerations

This research will be submitted for institutional ethics review prior to data collection. Because the topic involves potentially distressing material and asks participants to reflect on their own or their friends' conduct, particular attention will be paid to: obtaining informed consent that clearly explains the sensitive nature of the topic; ensuring participation is voluntary and withdrawal is possible at any point without penalty; protecting confidentiality through anonymization of transcripts and pseudonymization of friendship-group and individual identities; using anonymized vignettes rather than asking participants to name or describe identifiable third parties in ways that could expose those individuals or create legal risk; providing all participants with information about counseling and support resources; and ensuring focus-group facilitators are trained to manage disclosures of personal experiences of harassment sensitively

and to pause or redirect discussion if participants become distressed. Given the group format of the focus discussions, participants will be reminded that the research team cannot guarantee that other group members will maintain confidentiality outside the session and consent procedures will make this limitation explicit.

8. Significance of the Study

This study is positioned to make three contributions. Theoretically, it extends prejudiced norm theory and the continuum-of-violence framework beyond laboratory and single-incident contexts into the sustained, relational context of friendship groups, addressing calls in the literature for more ecologically valid research on disparagement humor [1], [4]. Empirically, it will generate original data on an everyday phenomenon that is widely acknowledged anecdotally but rarely studied systematically as a social process unfolding within real peer groups. Practically, findings can inform the design of byst ander-intervention training, campus prevention programming and public awareness efforts by identifying the specific interactional moments at which intervention by peers is most likely to be effective and by clarifying which forms of “banter” participants themselves recognize as precursors to harassment.

9. Limitations

- Self-report data on socially undesirable behavior (e.g., participation in misogynistic joking) is subject to social desirability bias, which will be partially mitigated through anonymous survey administration and non-judgmental interview framing.
- Recruiting intact friendship groups for focus discussions may itself alter the naturalness of the talk being studied (observer effects); findings should therefore be read as accounts and negotiations of norms rather than direct transcripts of unmonitored speech.
- The sample will be drawn primarily from university and community networks in a single regional context, which may limit generalizability to other cultural or age-group settings.
- Vignette-based prompts, while ethically necessary, are a simplification of lived interactions and may not fully capture the ambiguity of real-time exchanges.

10. Proposed Timeline

Phase	Activities	Duration
1. Preparation	Ethics approval; survey and interview instrument piloting	Months 1–2

2. Quantitative phase	Survey recruitment and administration; preliminary analysis	Months 3–4
3. Qualitative phase	Interviews and friendship-group focus discussions	Months 5–7
4. Analysis	Thematic analysis; integration of quantitative and qualitative findings	Months 8–9
5. Dissemination	Report/manuscript preparation; stakeholder briefing	Months 10–12

References

[1] T. E. Ford and M. A. Ferguson, "Social consequences of disparagement humor: A prejudiced norm theory," Pers. Soc. Psychol. Rev., vol. 8, no. 1, pp. 79–94, 2004.

[2] P. Glick and S. T. Fiske, "The ambivalent sexism inventory: Differentiating hostile and benevolent sexism," J. Pers. Soc. Psychol., vol. 70, no. 3, pp. 491–512, 1996.

[3] L. Kelly, Surviving Sexual Violence. Cambridge, U.K.: Polity Press, 1988.

[4] R. Kanyemba, "Fight or flight? Underst anding female students' response to sexist humour at an institution of higher learning in Zimbabwe," J. Contemp. Afr. Stud., vol. 40, no. 4, pp. 1–16, 2022.

[5] J. Whittle, D. Elder-Vass and K. Lumsden, "'There's a bit of banter': How male teenagers 'do boy' on social networking sites," in Online Othering: Exploring Digital Violence and Discrimination on the Web, K. Lumsden and E. Harmer, Eds. Cham, Switzerl and: Palgrave Macmillan, 2019, pp. 165–186.

[6] K. A. Nichols, "Moving beyond ideas of laddism: Conceptualising 'mischievous masculinities' as a new way of underst anding everyday sexism and gender relations," J. Gender Stud., vol. 27, no. 1, pp. 73–85, 2018.

[7] T. E. Ford, C. F. Boxer, J. Armstrong and J. R. Edel, "More than 'just a joke': The prejudice-releasing function of sexist humor," Pers. Soc. Psychol. Bull., vol. 34, no. 2, pp. 159–170, 2008.

[8] T. E. Ford, E. R. Wentzel and J. Lorion, "Effects of exposure to sexist humor on perceptions of normative tolerance of sexism," Eur. J. Soc. Psychol., vol. 31, no. 6, pp. 677–691, 2001.

[9] P. Hegarty, A. L. Stewart, I. G. E. Blockmans and M. A. H. Horvath, "The influence of magazines on men: Normalizing and challenging young men's prejudice with 'lads' mags'," Psychol. Men Masc., vol. 19, no. 1, pp. 131–144, 2018.

[10] N. L. Cabrera, "But we're not laughing: White male college students' racial joking and what this says about 'post-racial' discourse," J. Coll. Stud. Dev., vol. 55, no. 1, pp. 1–15, 2014.